

Chapter 169-1

Liang Shi never expected that Xu Qingzhu was a sister-complex.¹

But thinking back carefully, there had indeed been signs of this before.

Whether it was toward Xu Qingya or Sheng Yu, she was quite doting.

It was just that she appeared cold on the surface, so it wasn't obvious.

Looking deeper into it, Xu Qingzhu was the type of person who protected her own.

No matter what, she would protect her family first.

Liang Shi silently lit a candle for Zhou Yi'an in her heart.

She had been watching Zhou Yi'an and Su Meiqi's interactions from inside earlier, and always felt there was something indescribable between them.

With Zhou Yi'an's personality, she wouldn't be this patient with someone she wasn't interested in.

"Do you still hate Zhou Yi'an?" Liang Shi teased while opening the car door for her. "Teacher Xu holds grudges."

"I don't hold grudges." Xu Qingzhu got in the car. "If I have a grudge, I usually settle it on the spot."

Liang Shi: "..."

"She was pretty terrible at first." Xu Qingzhu said, "I really disliked her. But thinking about it later, I also played a trick on her."

Liang Shi remembered that time—she and Xu Qingzhu had played that trick together.

"Later, when I found out she was RT's Designer of the Year, it got a bit better." Xu Qingzhu's voice was still cold, but since she was talking to Liang Shi, it was much gentler. "Maybe it's a talent filter. Now that we've worked together for so long, I quite admire her work style."

Liang Shi understood.

She admired her work style but didn't like her as a person.

"What if Meiqi really does like her?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu paused. "Then let her like her."

She turned her face to look at Liang Shi's profile. It happened to be a red light, and the car stopped. Liang Shi also turned to look at her.

Their eyes met.

Xu Qingzhu smiled lightly, the corners of her lips curving up slightly, light dancing in her eyes. "She's an adult now. She has her own judgment."

A moment later, the car started again and merged into traffic.

Xu Qingzhu's voice was languid and casual. She drew out her words when calling Liang Shi's name: "Teacher Liang~"

"Hmm?"

"I just said it casually, and you actually took it seriously." Xu Qingzhu chuckled. "Am I that kind of bad person?"

"What if you're just being overprotective?" Liang Shi teased.

Xu Qingzhu propped her fingers against her temple. "Even that has limits. When it comes to matters of the heart, you can't stop it."

"Just like when I insisted on getting married back then. My parents didn't want me to, but... on one hand, I was pressured by the company, and on the other hand, it was because I wanted to do it. Even if they hadn't agreed back then, I would have done it anyway." Xu Qingzhu softened her voice. "If the main road doesn't work, you can always take a secret path. Young girls in love usually don't think straight."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Who are you talking about?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu looked straight at her, her voice light and airy. "Me."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Oh." Liang Shi was amused by her. "So were you love-brained before, or are you love-brained now?"

Xu Qingzhu thought for two seconds. "Before, I was love-brained. Now, I'm..."

She paused for a long time, then said slowly and deliberately, word by word: "Fallen—in—love."

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1. Sister-complex (妹控): A term borrowed from Japanese (siscon/シスコン), referring to someone who is extremely protective and doting toward their younger sister or sister-like figures. ⇐

Chapter 169-2

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It had to be said—Liang Shi had been thoroughly charmed.

That night when they got back, she pressed Xu Qingzhu against the wall. "Just how many books did you read?"

Xu Qingzhu's gaze wandered. "Not that many."

Liang Shi wore an expression of disbelief.

Xu Qingzhu defended herself. "We're capable of learning by analogy."

Liang Shi bit her lip lightly. "Then show me your analogical skills now."

There was a hint of provocation in her voice.

Xu Qingzhu licked her lips, then gently bit her lower lip. Her hand rested on the back of Liang Shi's neck as she slightly tiptoed and leaned in to lightly touch the corner of Liang Shi's lips.

A fleeting touch.

For just an instant, she felt that slightly cool temperature.

But soon it turned scorching hot.

Too many sensations intermingled.

Liang Shi was stunned. She lowered her head slightly to meet Xu Qingzhu's gaze.

Their eyes met. Xu Qingzhu's figure was reflected in Liang Shi's light brown pupils. She unconsciously swallowed, her throat moving slightly.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers tapped lightly on the back of her neck, tantalizingly close yet distant.

Then she slowly leaned in and kissed her jawline.

Again, a fleeting touch.

Liang Shi suddenly felt her body grow hot. The hand around Xu Qingzhu's waist tightened.

She somewhat regretted provoking Xu Qingzhu.

But along with regret, there was also secret delight and pleasure.

The secret delight was the majority.

Liang Shi stared straight at her, still holding back from moving, as if testing the results of her analogical learning.

Xu Qingzhu's lips curved slightly as she gently pressed them together.

The color of her lips changed in an instant—from pink to white, then to a deeper pink.

In the few seconds of silence, one could hear the sound of traffic flowing below, and faintly hear conversations of pedestrians on the street. But these were all just background noise.

In this quiet and small space, Xu Qingzhu's back was against the wall, with Liang Shi in front of her.

Her back was cool; the warmth was in front of her.

Xu Qingzhu's smile slowly widened, and then she couldn't hold back anymore, letting out a soft laugh.

So soft that just as Liang Shi was reacting, Xu Qingzhu had already kissed her throat.

Swallowing all of Liang Shi's words.

In that instant, it was as if her brain flashed white, and the string called reason suddenly snapped.

She could almost hear a sound in her ears.

Accompanying her heartbeat.

The sensation on her neck made her feel numb, as if electrified, the tingling spreading through her entire body.

It made her forget to breathe.

Only when Xu Qingzhu noticed she wasn't breathing did she let go. Having just teased someone, her voice was cool yet slightly husky. "Breathe."

It was like suddenly pressing a switch. Everything around them began to flow.

Light and shadow drifted, and the air was filled with enchantment.

Liang Shi lowered her head, drawing closer to Xu Qingzhu.

Amid her soft laughter, she slowly moved close to her lips.

Liang Shi's hand rested on Xu Qingzhu's waist. That waist was slender yet alluring.

Liang Shi held it gently, protectively.

When the kiss ended, Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu in a low voice, "Do you want to have another wedding with me?"

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Asking this question wasn't a spur-of-the-moment decision.

It could only be said that the atmosphere had given Liang Shi courage, but before she could drown in those eyes, she asked this question.

Xu Qingzhu only hesitated for a second before kissing her again, agreeing readily: "Sure."

If asked what the most moving part of Lin Luoxi and Sally's wedding was, Liang Shi thought it was still the moment when two people stood before each other in wedding dresses, gazing at each other affectionately, sincerely making promises to each other.

It was a very sacred thing.

On ordinary days, even doing something like that would feel insincere, or like deception.

But in that moment, it wouldn't.

Liang Shi looked forward to experiencing such a scene with Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu was married, but not to her.

There had been a wedding, but it wasn't grand, and it wasn't with her.

She just wanted a wedding with Xu Qingzhu. There was nothing wrong with that, right?

No, there wasn't.

Liang Shi convinced herself.

But now wasn't a good time for a wedding. It was the end of the year, and Xu Qingzhu's company was very busy. Once the year-end rush was over, the spring new products would launch—another tough battle.

And Liang Shi's career had just started. She had nothing yet.

By the time Liang Shi was truly ready, Xu Qingzhu would probably be visibly pregnant. Having a wedding under such circumstances—never mind Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi herself couldn't forgive herself.

So Liang Shi thought they could have the wedding when the baby was older.

But she wanted to propose again before the baby was born.

Liang Shi made a detailed plan while Xu Qingzhu was sleeping, and only then went to bed.

When she lay down, Xu Qingzhu nuzzled into her arms, like a cat.

After Little New Year's Eve passed, all the days that followed flew by quickly.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu went back to the Xu family home for a meal, and also got together with Liang Xinzhou and the others once.

But after all, Qiu Zimin stood between them. During holidays, Liang Shi couldn't get too close to Liang Xinzhou and the others.

So they only met that one time.

Ling Dang and Sheng Yu were on winter break and would occasionally come to stay for a day.

Rainbow had already gone abroad with her mother when vacation started, supposedly to see her father.

While at Liang Shi's home, Ling Dang called Rainbow to ask if it was fun abroad, when she would come back, and whether she wasn't planning to come back to attend kindergarten.

Rainbow answered hesitantly.

Sheng Yu leaned into the camera and huffed, "Hmph, you heartless thing. Ling Dang even cried."

Rainbow lowered her head. "I'm sorry."

Liang Shi, who was listening nearby, felt something was off. After they hung up, she asked Zhou Li and learned that Zhou Li had already quit her job at Dongheng and had taken Rainbow abroad to settle there permanently.

Rainbow's father was in a laboratory overseas. Zhou Li didn't go into detail, but Liang Shi guessed it was some kind of scientific work that required confidentiality.

It was quite a pity.

Zhou Li said that once Rainbow's father finished his current work, they would probably return to China.

It was just unclear when that would be.

Zhou Li could only smile bitterly and say, "With their kind of work, it easily takes three to five years. If it's longer, it could even be over a decade."

Liang Shi reminded Rainbow to eat well and sleep well.

Rainbow then secretly asked Liang Shi, "Is Liang Wenxuan still crying?"

Liang Shi shook her head. "Not anymore. She's just a child at heart. She'll be fine after a while."

Rainbow said "oh" and puffed out her cheeks. "Then goodbye, Big Sister Liang."

Liang Shi smiled. "When I have time, I'll come visit you."

She purely treated Rainbow as a friend. Even when talking about Ling Dang, she clearly separated herself from Ling Dang.

As if she and Rainbow were in the same age group, while Ling Dang was in another.

In reality, Rainbow and Ling Dang were both kindergarten children.

The days at home passed quickly. Sometimes she had to coax the children, and sometimes she had to coax Xu Qingzhu.

But looking more closely, Xu Qingzhu actually coaxed her more often.

Mainly because Xu Qingzhu always teased her, then would coax her afterward.

Liang Shi never really got angry. It was just that sometimes she was teased until her heart itched. When she was truly annoyed, she would bite Xu Qingzhu's collarbone, and Xu Qingzhu would have to wear a high-collared shirt to work the next day.

While applying powder to cover the teeth marks or strawberry marks in the bathroom, Xu Qingzhu would leave the door open and say to Liang Shi, "Good thing it's still winter. You can't do this in summer."

"If you didn't bully me, I wouldn't do it," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Xu Qingzhu protested, "How did I bully you?"

Liang Shi walked over and pinched her face. "You know yourself."

Xu Qingzhu then mischievously leaned over to kiss her, smearing the lipstick she had just applied onto Liang Shi's freshly done makeup.

Liang Shi was helpless. She pinched her waist. "And this doesn't count as bullying me?"

Xu Qingzhu said proudly, "This is a loving kiss."

After that incident, the two of them got along more and more naturally.

Neither of them brought up the nightmare. Occasionally when it came up in conversation, Xu Qingzhu would bite Liang Shi's arm and scold her affectionately, "That's what you get for being bad."

Liang Shi would apologize to her in a muffled voice.

But such moments were rare. Those days had been hard for Xu Qingzhu too, so she didn't bring up these things often.

Those gloomy days were simply turned over and left behind.

When Liang Shi had free time, she would occasionally tell Xu Qingzhu about her experiences in that other world as bedtime stories, though she always glossed over the heavy parts.

One time, they even talked about being kidnapped as children.

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Liang Shi said, "I don't know why I was so stubborn as a child either. Actually, thinking about it now, it was just a matter of one sentence."

"Even if you were asked to do it now, you still wouldn't." Xu Qingzhu said with certainty. "Because that's just who Liang Shi is."

"That's not true." Liang Shi said, "When you were kidnapped by Chen Liuying before, I was also quite..."

"No, no, no." Xu Qingzhu said, "That's because the person who was kidnapped was me. But if it were you, you definitely wouldn't have done that."

Liang Shi: "..."

Having been struck at a vital point, Liang Shi was momentarily speechless.

After a moment, Liang Shi finally smiled and said, "A lot of people used to say that the rigid are easily broken. Over the years, I've actually been tempering my character. I think I can bend and stretch pretty well now. Grandma once told me that the most valuable thing a person can have is self-awareness."

"Not in the way it's used to insult people nowadays. What she meant was, only you truly understand what kind of person you are. No matter what others say about you, those thousands of versions aren't the real you. So it doesn't matter what you say on the surface. You can be two-faced, you can flatter and fawn—but you have to know that it's wrong. That's enough."

On the late night when she thought of her grandmother, Liang Shi also had a dream. She dreamed of taking her grandparents to the seaside, fulfilling their wish.

When she woke up, tears had soaked half her pillow. Xu Qingzhu was right beside her, watching her, her heart aching terribly.

Xu Qingzhu handed her tissues, but that wasn't enough. On a whim, she took her to the outskirts of the city to see the ocean.

These days were peaceful and warm for Liang Shi.

Every day was radiant and worth commemorating.

This New Year was spent at the Su family's home.

Since Xu Qingzhu was going to the Su family's, she brought Sheng Linlang and the others along.

Xu Guangyao had already stepped down from his decision-making position at the company. For nearly half a year, he had been traveling everywhere with Sheng Linlang. After returning to Haizhou, he had picked up his old profession again, designed a whole set, and spent every day hammering away at home, planning to make a set of jewelry.

He said it was to make up for the regret of his hasty marriage to Sheng Linlang back then.

This New Year was much livelier than usual.

Xu Qingzhu also announced her pregnancy during the reunion dinner.

Everyone was shocked, but more than that, they were happy.

So that evening, Su Zhe and Xu Guangyao got completely drunk, even to the point of calling each other brothers.

When Su Zhe drank too much, he had no filter. He started complaining about Sheng Linlang's parents. Even though his wife slapped his back several times, he didn't get the hint. But then he changed the subject: "Those two weren't good people, but strangely, the children they raised all turned out pretty well. If that boy Sheng Qinglin were still alive, he would have also..."

"Smack—" Mrs. Su slapped Su Zhe on the back of his neck. The pain made Su Zhe swallow all his words and just argue with her: "Why did you hit me?!"

Mrs. Su said matter-of-factly, "There was a mosquito."

Everyone: "...?"

But at least it stopped Su Zhe from continuing.

However, everyone present had still heard the name Sheng Qinglin, and they all fell silent.

Especially Sheng Linlang and Su Yao.

Their gazes met in the air, each seeing the other's reddened eyes.

Xu Qingzhu walked over and asked Sheng Linlang, "When... are we going to pay respects to my father?"

Sheng Linlang was stunned, realizing that she had changed how she addressed things.

Xu Qingzhu bit her lower lip. She decided that she had to do this eventually, so she steeled her heart and called out, "Auntie."

Sheng Linlang's eyes immediately welled up with tears. She smiled and responded, then said, "The fifth day of the new year."

Regarding Xu Qingzhu changing her form of address back, Sheng Linlang and Xu Guangyao felt a bit sad, but they didn't say anything.

She should have been calling them aunt and uncle all along.

Xu Guangyao had hinted at this twice before, but Xu Qingzhu had glossed over it each time.

On this reunion night, Xu Qingzhu finally changed how she addressed them.

Afterward, Sheng Linlang even asked if she wanted to change her name. Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I've been using it for so many years now. There's no need to change it. Everyone knows what I'm called. Let's wait for my child—I'll change it back for her in the future."

From now on, this family would still bear the Sheng surname. That wasn't a problem.

Actually, it was just a name—a label, really.

But sometimes when the burden on one's shoulders grew heavier and the bonds grew stronger, surnames would feel especially important.

After the reunion dinner, when they left the Su family's home, traffic flowed on the roads like shuttles. The city was bright as day, and the whole world felt like a huge, gentle cocoon wrapping them inside.

After leaving the bustle behind, people would feel a great sense of loss.

No matter where you walked, it felt lonely.

Liang Shi turned on the car stereo. It happened to be "Flock of Lonely Birds," the song Qi Jiao had recommended to Chen Mian.

The singer's voice was very gentle, with a hint of huskiness—the classic voice for singing love songs.

"What lies at the end of the universe

Have you ever been there

We made wishes under the same sky

What did you wish for back then

I was secretly watching you

And forgot to even make a wish

...

Your life isn't that bad

You still have me entangled with you

Even lonely birds can find companionship

...

I will remember you

And if I forget, I'll let the lonely bird carry my wishes to you

Even if we're destined to part

I'm still willing to be with you

..."

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the car seat, softly humming along.

Liang Shi suddenly spoke. "This is a song that Qi Jiao and Chen Mian really liked."

"I really like it too." Xu Qingzhu's gaze shifted to the side. Along Liang Shi's profile, she could see the bustling scene outside.

The entire city was immersed in festivity, with fireworks blooming in the sky.

Liang Shi said, "I fell in love with it after listening to it once."

Just then, the song was reaching its end. Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked, "Liang Shi, are you lonely?"

Liang Shi was startled. "Huh?"

"Stop playing dumb." Xu Qingzhu said, "Do you want to find your family? Like how Gu Xingyue found her mother, or like how my mom and I reunited. Actually, I think what you said to comfort me back then was right—we're not at an age where we need parents anymore. We can choose not to have them and still live brilliant lives. But at times like this, I often feel like you're lonely."

Liang Shi: "..."

There were moments when she did feel this way.

Even when surrounded by crowds of people, nowhere felt like home.

It was a bit better now—she knew she had Xu Qingzhu, had their little home.

This feeling was especially strong when she was separated from Xu Qingzhu. When she had gone to stay at Zhao Xuning's place, sometimes she couldn't sleep at night and would gaze at the lights of countless homes, giving rise to an unrealistic fantasy.

In this vast city, was there a light that shone just for her?

Was there someone waiting for her to come home?

Was there someone who would treat her like a child no matter how old she got?

This kind of emotional need, when absent since childhood, was actually very real. But people often hid this need away, as if exposing even a little of it was a sign of weakness.

As time passed, this longing would be buried deeper and deeper.

Yes, this kind of emotion wasn't necessary at their age. But if they had it, it would truly be the icing on the cake.

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Xu Qingzhu leaned there and said, "Before today, I didn't feel this strongly about it. I would have thought it was something I could take or leave. But thinking about it carefully today, it seems like I've gained a kind of strength over the past six months. I know I have people to protect, and people protecting me. Like... my mom. I know that if there's anyone in this world who would give unconditionally for me, she would definitely be the first."

As Xu Qingzhu spoke, her eyes welled up with tears and her voice became somewhat choked. "See, I haven't actually spent much time with her properly, but she can give me this sense of security. That's really important to me. I feel like I'm not afraid of anything anymore. Even if... I mean, just in case, even if one day our relationship really came to an end, I wouldn't feel like my existence in this world is meaningless, because they are also part of the meaning of my existence."

Liang Shi's hands on the steering wheel were trembling.

The car had just arrived downstairs, but neither of them moved. The lights inside the car were still on.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her. "I was thinking, if only someone could give you this same sense of security. If only someone could love you like this too. Not just me alone loving you, not just me alone giving you this confidence."

A tear suddenly fell from Liang Shi's eye.

She closed her eyes and opened them again, then reached out to pat Xu Qingzhu's head. "Why so sentimental?"

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "Actually, I'm really afraid that if one day I'm gone, what would you do if you couldn't go on living? So I want you to have bonds with more people. That way, even in days without me, you can still shine."

Liang Shi: "..."

"What nonsense are you saying?" Liang Shi pinched her face. "You're going to live to a hundred years old with me."

Xu Qingzhu unbuckled her seatbelt and nodded. "Okay."

When they got out of the car, Liang Shi suddenly said, "Then I'll give it a try."

Xu Qingzhu smiled and nodded at her.

"What if she doesn't want to acknowledge me?" Liang Shi asked. "Or what if it's like with Guo Xinran—she got her parents' love, but was rejected by her siblings. What then?"

Xu Qingzhu paused, then walked firmly to Liang Shi's side. "Please, you're my Teacher Liang. Who wouldn't like you? Guo Xinran was like that because she was restless and wanted too much. We don't want anything. Are we short on money?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She could hear a sense of wealth and confidence in those words.

Xu Qingzhu said, "We're not short on money. If they are, we can even lend them some. But I also have a selfish motive."

"What?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu held her hand, swinging it gently back and forth in the air. "If we find them first, the initiative and the choice are in our hands. How can you be sure your parents aren't looking for you? Rather than letting the unexpected come knocking, we might as well turn the unexpected into the expected."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her perspective had been opened up.

After a long while, Liang Shi said, "I was abandoned outside Shi'an Hospital, in a near-death state."